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Fancy some mammoth?

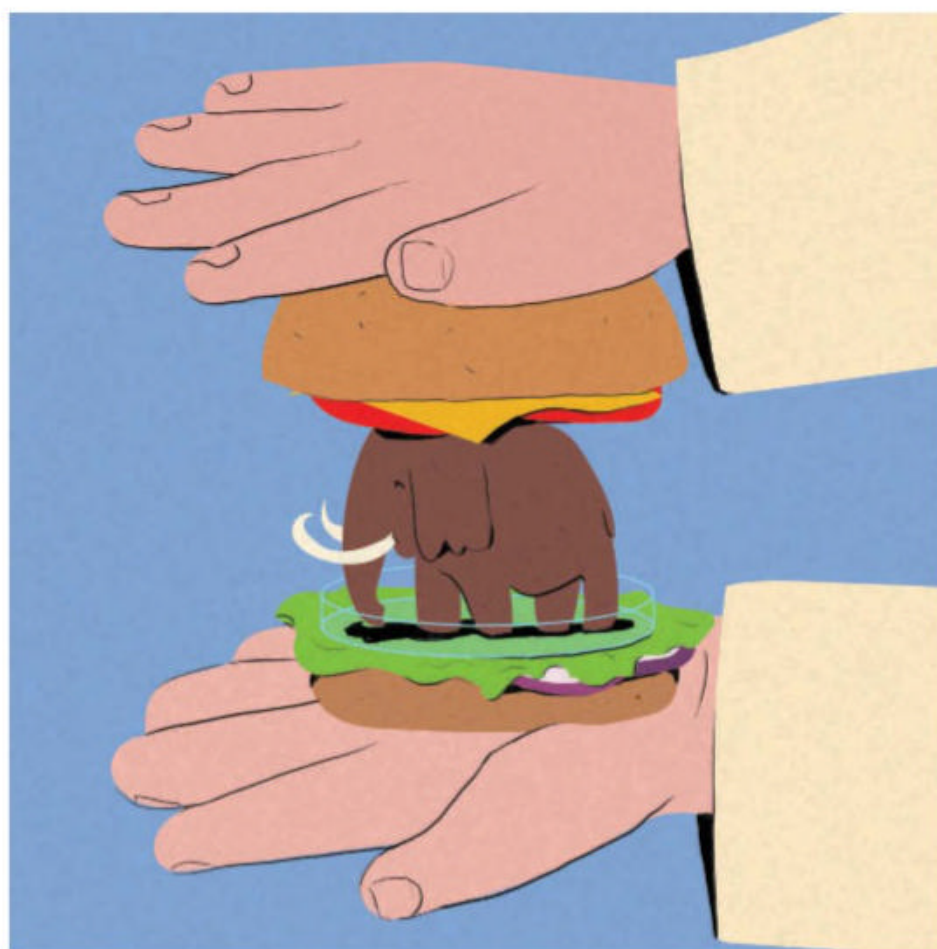
The lab-grown meat industry needs to perfect and normalise the staples before jumping to exotic alternatives, argues **Brian Kateman**

PICTURE this: it's 10 years from now and you are deciding what to get for lunch. You're stuck between a raptor meatball sub or a dodo chorizo burrito. It is a delicious problem to have – or maybe a creepy one. Or both.

It can be stunning to take a step back sometimes and realise that we are living in the future. Technologies that seemed fantastical in movies last century are fast becoming part of our regular lives. The food tech sector is no exception, with start-ups making cell-cultivated meat – real meat grown from animal cells rather than slaughtered animals – some of it sourced from stranger origins than you might think.

Start-up Primeval Foods has yet to release its creations to the public, but it plans to specialise in “exotic” cell-cultivated meats that most people would otherwise never have the chance to try, like tiger and zebra. Earlier this year, Vow Foods created a meatball using DNA imitating that of a woolly mammoth. It is on display in a Dutch museum, not making its way into anyone's melty Italian subs (yet), but it was an attention-grabbing moment for the nascent cultivated meat industry and was featured in the press worldwide.

In July, *The Atlantic* published a piece on the state of cell-cultivated meat as a consumer product. The article was titled “Open your mind to unicorn meat”, pointing to the sorts of hybrid meats that some are interested in creating, which



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would combine the most delicious qualities of different animals.

As an advocate of cellular agriculture, the framing of cell-cultivated meat as a science experiment concerns me. Sure, the idea of mammoth meatballs and a steak with, as *The Atlantic* put it, “the density of flavor of an Oreo” are interesting to think about from a scientific perspective, but will those descriptions make the average person's mouth water? I think not.

To the industry's credit, there are more grounded projects in the works too, like the cell-cultivated chicken breast from Upside Foods,

which recently cleared all regulatory hurdles in the US and is now on sale at Bar Crenn in San Francisco. But when the industry presents itself to the public through attention-grabbing headlines about mammoth meat, it isn't doing itself any favours.

Perception is a major concern when trying to introduce the public to new foods. A study last year found that cell-cultivated meat is “viewed negatively on all attributes except animal friendliness”, including its perceived safety, healthiness and enjoyability. The result? Only one-quarter of consumers indicated

a willingness to eat cell-cultivated chicken and beef. We really need to sell people on cell-cultivated meat, because behind all the culinary imagination, there lies a pressing issue: the need to end industrial animal agriculture.

Every year in the US alone, around 10 billion land animals are slaughtered within the factory farm system. Industrial animal agriculture is responsible not only for acts of animal cruelty, but for environmental degradation that affects entire ecosystems and for major public health threats like zoonotic diseases (those that jump from animal to human hosts). Ending our reliance on industrial animal agriculture to feed the world can't be a far-off goal.

So, I am all for innovation, but these far-flung ideas shouldn't be the face of the cell-cultivated meat movement, at least not until the cell-cultivated versions of staple foods like chicken, pork and beef have been perfected and, more importantly, normalised. Plus, they need to be climate-friendly.

If the goal is to provide an animal-friendly, eco-friendly, safer alternative that consumers are happy to replace their meat with, we probably shouldn't be encouraging a mental association between cell-cultivated meat and, well, science experiments. ■



Brian Kateman is a writer and founder of the Reducetarian Foundation, working to reduce the use of animal products